



PARENT & FAMILY COMMUNICATION

Family Language Toolkit

Practical guides for parents navigating school and health settings in more than one language.

Short, plain-language guides for the moments that matter most: requesting an interpreter, preparing for a parent–teacher conference, getting ready for a checkup, and decoding the forms schools send home.

Your right to understand

You are your family’s strongest advocate — and you do not have to do it in a language you are still learning, alone. Two systems families deal with most, schools and healthcare, both have obligations to communicate with you in a way you understand.

SETTING	WHAT YOU CAN GENERALLY ASK FOR
Healthcare	Free interpretation and key documents in your language at providers that receive federal funding. Ask: “ <i>Quisiera un intérprete.</i> ”
Public schools	An interpreter for meetings and translation of essential information about your child’s education. Ask the front office what is available.

ONE PHRASE WORTH MEMORIZING

“We would like an interpreter, please.” · “*Quisiéramos un intérprete, por favor.*”

Say it early — at the front desk, on the phone, or at the start of a meeting — rather than waiting until you are lost.

Preparing for a parent–teacher conference

Conferences are short — often ten to fifteen minutes. A little preparation lets you use that time for what matters.

Bring these

- ☐ A notebook and your child’s most recent report card or progress report
- ☐ Your top three questions, written down in advance
- ☐ A request for an interpreter if you want one — made when you schedule

Good questions to ask

- ☐ Is my child on track for their grade level in reading and math?
- ☐ What is one thing my child does well, and one thing to work on?
- ☐ How can I support this learning at home?
- ☐ How would you prefer I contact you, and how often?

YOU MAY HEAR...	IT USUALLY MEANS...
“Benchmark” / “grade level”	The skill target expected for your child’s grade at this point in the year.
“Below / approaching / meets”	How your child is doing against that target — not a final judgment.
“Intervention”	Extra support the school provides. Usually a good thing; ask what it involves.

GUIDE 2

Getting ready for a checkup

Families who prepare before a medical visit consistently report better, calmer appointments. This works for a child’s visit or your own.

- ☐ Write down symptoms and when they started (dates help more than “a while ago”)
- ☐ List current medications, vitamins, and doses — a phone photo of each bottle works
- ☐ Note any allergies and past reactions
- ☐ Prepare two or three questions; you will not remember them all in the moment
- ☐ Bring your insurance card and, for children, the vaccine record

IF A CHILD IS BEING ASKED TO INTERPRET

It is common but not required, and for medical conversations it puts children in a hard position. You can decline and request a professional interpreter instead — it is your right, and it protects your child.

GUIDE 3

Decoding common school forms

TERM ON THE FORM	WHAT IT MEANS
Permission / consent slip	Your signature allowing your child to do an activity, like a field trip.
Free & reduced-price meals	A program that lowers or removes school meal costs for families who qualify.
IEP / 504 plan	A written plan of extra support or accommodations for a student who needs them.
Emergency contact	Who the school calls if they cannot reach you — list someone who speaks English if you can.
Home Language Survey	Asks what languages you speak at home; it helps the school offer language services.

Educational guidance only, not legal advice. Rules vary by state and institution — when in doubt, ask the school or provider directly. Reviewed by MSC volunteers.